

ScreenJoule: Electrothermal Design of Reactor Elements under Power-Supply and Electrode Constraints

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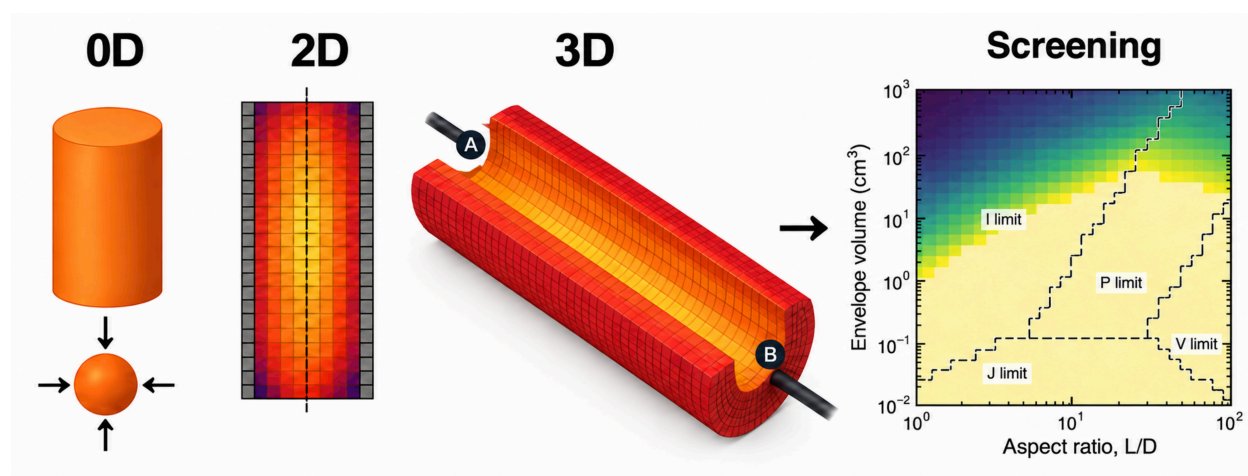
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Abstract

Direct Joule heating links reactor temperature to material properties, element geometry, power-supply limits, and electrode configuration. ScreenJoule is an open-source browser toolkit that combines lumped, axisymmetric, and three-dimensional electrothermal calculations for reactor-element design. Lumped calculations screen material and geometry combinations for sufficient heating capacity, while spatial calculations resolve internal temperature gradients and current distribution. The design examples show how electrical constraints limit attainable temperature and how electrode width affects temperature uniformity and available heating power. Numerical benchmarks, mesh refinement, and published-case comparisons assess the calculations.

Graphical Abstract



1. Introduction

Direct resistance heating generates heat within an electrically conducting reactor element, shortening the heat-transfer path associated with furnace heating.^{1,2} Electrified methane reforming, structured SiSiC reactors, and internally heated hydrocarbon crackers demonstrate its use in high-temperature chemical processing.³⁻⁷ Designing these elements requires estimates of the temperature and heating rate attainable with a chosen material and power supply. An experimentalist must select the element dimensions and mass, determine whether the available supply can reach the target temperature, and assess the temperature variation within the element. When heating is insufficient, these estimates guide changes to the material, geometry, supply, or thermal enclosure.

These choices are linked through electrical resistance and the heat balance. Changing an element's length or cross-section changes its resistance, thermal mass, and exposed surface area. At fixed voltage, the resistance sets Joule power until a current or power limit is reached. A change in aspect ratio can therefore shift operation between current-limited and voltage-limited regimes.^{1,7} The net power after heat loss, divided by the element's heat capacity, determines the lumped heating rate; the steady temperature is reached when heat generation balances heat loss. Temperature-dependent resistivity further changes the operating point during heating. Electrode contact geometry and thermal conduction determine how the resulting heat is distributed, so an adequate mean temperature can coexist with local overheating.

Lumped energy balances and spatially resolved models describe different parts of this design problem. Mittal et al. combined three-dimensional Joule-heating CFD with a lumped energy-balance model,⁸ while Sundaramoorthy et al. compared volume-averaged heat-transfer models for structured reactors with channel-resolved CFD.⁹ Scientific software also makes calculations accessible for repeated use: Energy2D provides interactive heat-transfer simulations,¹⁰ fuelcell combines electrochemical data processing with a graphical interface,¹¹ and OpenMKM provides reusable multiscale catalytic reactor calculations.¹² For initial Joule-heater design, the practical task is to evaluate material, dimension, and supply combinations across a broad range, then resolve current paths and temperature gradients in selected configurations.

ScreenJoule connects these steps through lumped, axisymmetric, and three-dimensional electrothermal calculations in a browser. The design studies quantify target-temperature capacity and mass-dependent heating times, material-dependent temperature distributions, electrode-contact and supply constraints, and geometry-dependent heating at fixed power. Parameter sweeps identify feasible combinations and show how changes in individual design variables affect heating. The models treat rods, tubes, tapes, foams, and monolith walls with a continuous conducting path between electrodes. Solid fraction and effective properties represent porous elements. Particle beds require a separate contact-network description because compression and particle contacts determine their resistance and local heating.

2. Model Formulation

2.1. Software workflow

Joule0D determines the resistance, available power and lumped temperature for a selected material, geometry and power supply. Joule2D uses the operating point to resolve axisymmetric element and enclosure temperatures, including heating and cooling transients (**Figure 1**). Joule3D solves the electrical potential and temperature in a three-dimensional solid and screens pairs of design variables (**Figure 4**). The workspaces serve successive design questions. Conditions must be matched explicitly when comparing their predictions. Calculated data can be exported for analysis. The lumped and axisymmetric model schematics are given in Figure S1. ScreenJoule supports design screening and selection of cases for detailed CFD analysis.

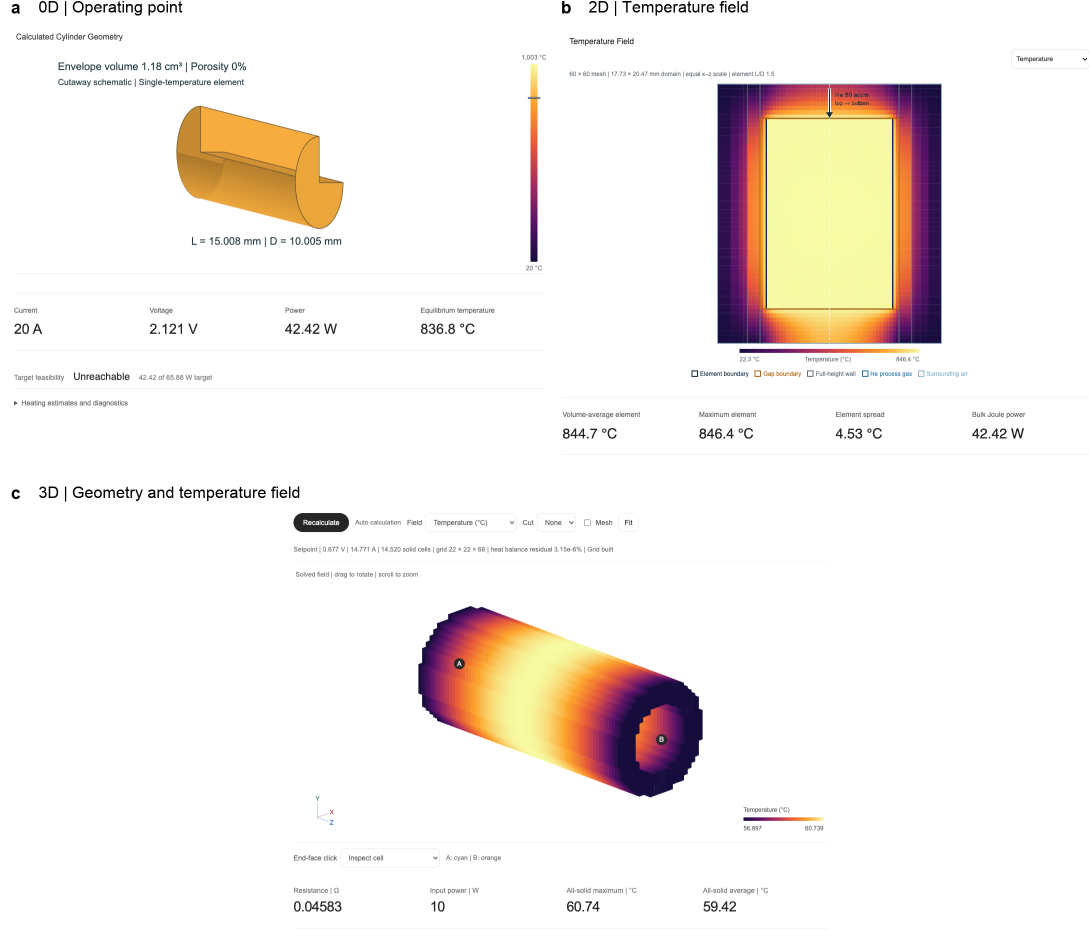


Figure 1. ScreenJoule workspaces. (a) Lumped operating point, with a cylinder cutaway schematic. (b) Axisymmetric temperature field and heat balance. (c) Three-dimensional geometry, electrode locations and temperature field. Panels a and b use the default dense SiC cylinder; panel c uses a separate hollow-tube example at 10 W. Color scales are local to each panel. The cutaway in panel a is a schematic of the solid interior.

2.2. Operating point

For a cylindrical element with solid inventory V_s , void fraction ϕ , and aspect ratio $\lambda = L/D$, the solid fraction is $f_s = 1 - \phi$ and the envelope volume is $V_{env} = V_s/f_s$. The dimensions and effective conducting area are

$$D = \left(\frac{4V_{env}}{\pi\lambda} \right)^{1/3}, \quad L = \lambda D, \quad A_{eff} = f_s \frac{\pi D^2}{4} \quad (1)$$

The element resistance is evaluated at the volume-average element temperature. Including two equal contact resistances,

$$R_{bulk} = \rho_e(T_{avg}) \frac{L}{A_{eff}}, \quad R_{total} = R_{bulk} + 2R_c \quad (2)$$

Voltage, current and power ratings apply simultaneously: a 150 V / 40 A / 2 kW supply can deliver at most 13.3 A at 150 V. In automatic mode, the solver selects the current from the most restrictive of four ceilings,

$$I = \min(I_{\max}, \frac{V_{\max}}{R_{total}}, \sqrt{\frac{P_{\max}}{R_{total}}}, J_{\max}A_{eff}) \quad (3)$$

and deposits $P_{bulk} = I^2 R_{bulk}$ in the element. Contact resistance contributes to the operating point; contact heat is reported and not deposited, because explicit contacts and electrodes are outside the thermal domain.

2.3. Local power distribution

A local electrical calculation determines where the bulk power is deposited (Figure S1c). Within the element the electric potential satisfies

$$\nabla \cdot [\sigma(T)\nabla\Phi] = 0 \quad (4)$$

for a unit potential difference between its axial ends. The local dissipation $q'''_{unit} = \sigma(T)|\nabla\Phi|^2$ is normalized to the scalar bulk power,

$$q'''(r, z) = P_{bulk} \frac{q'''_{unit}(r, z)}{\int_{V_e} q'''_{unit} dV}, \quad \int_{V_e} q''' dV = P_{bulk} \quad (5)$$

The local field redistributes a fixed bulk power. Its calculated terminal resistance does not update the global operating point, so localized electrothermal feedback that changes the total current or power requires a fully coupled field-circuit model.

2.4. Temperature field

The thermal calculation uses an axisymmetric finite-volume domain containing the element, gas gap, containment wall, surrounding air, and axial process-gas regions (Figure S1). The stationary temperature satisfies

$$\frac{1}{r} \frac{\partial}{\partial r} (kr \frac{\partial T}{\partial r}) + \frac{\partial}{\partial z} (k \frac{\partial T}{\partial z}) + q''' = 0 \quad (6)$$

The model includes conduction across material interfaces, gas-gap conduction, element-to-wall gray-body radiation, wall and surrounding-air heat transfer, boundary convection and radiation, and prescribed process-gas sensible-enthalpy transport. Transient calculations add thermal storage. Temperature-dependent properties and radiative heat transfer are updated iteratively (Figure S1c); the numerical methods are given in SI Section S1.4.^{13,14} Convergence is evaluated from the temperature update, linear residual, and energy closure. The Supporting Information gives the discretization, boundary conditions, and property models.

For the opt-in porous-body closure, volumetric element storage is $(1 - \epsilon) \rho_s c_p$, where ϵ is skeleton density. Solid fraction scales mass and conducting area; effective thermal conductivity is specified independently of this scaling. The present design calculations assume isotropic effective $k = 60 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$ and examine 20 and 120 $\text{W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$ separately. These inputs do not resolve monolith channels or determine reacting-gas temperature.

2.5. Three-dimensional electrode model

For **Figure 4**, Joule3D solves steady electrical conduction and heat conduction on a Cartesian finite-volume mesh. The electrical potential sets local Joule heating; the terminal voltage is constrained by the requested power and voltage, current and power ceilings. The two ideal end-electrode contact regions have zero thermal conductance to the terminal sink. Other exposed solid faces lose heat by convection and radiation to a 25 °C ambient, with a heat-transfer coefficient of $15 \text{ W m}^{-2} \text{ K}^{-1}$ and emissivity 0.8. Gas flow, the enclosure and reaction heat are excluded from this example. The 3D calculation is separate from the scalar-to-axisymmetric formulation above; its verification scope is not inherited from the 2D benchmarks.

2.6. Numerical verification

The manufactured-solution error decreases across seven meshes (Figure S2a). The doubling sequence 30→60→120 gives L2 spatial orders of 2.05 and 2.06. Five physical meshes resolve the selected porous SiC case (Figure S2b); the peak changes by 0.079 K between the two finest meshes. Radial and annular analytic-limit comparisons, and transient time-step checks, are given in Figure S2. These checks assess numerical implementation. Material properties and boundary conditions require separate experimental assessment.¹⁵

Literature comparisons quantify the sensitivity of calculated temperatures to external heat loss and process heat demand (Figure S7).

3. Results and Discussion

3.1. Porous SiC design case

The spatial reference case uses an 80 cm^3 envelope, porosity 0.5 and $L/D = 30$. Its solid mass is 128.4 g, with a length of 450.9 mm and diameter of 15.03 mm. A 150 V, 40 A, 2 kW supply drives the selected element at the power ceiling. The 0D balance gives 1084.2 °C; the 2D field gives an average of 1096.4 °C and a peak of 1110.0 °C. The selected case remains below the 1200 °C display threshold. This threshold is a plotting limit, not a component service rating.

3.2. Target-temperature capacity maps

The main and supplementary screening studies comprise 6,833 lumped evaluations. The design question is whether the available electrical heating can balance heat loss at the target temperature. **Figure 2** evaluates both quantities at 1200 °C. Map colors represent the power ratio at 1200 °C. A ratio above one indicates sufficient power to maintain the lumped target under the stated losses; startup time and internal peak temperature are evaluated separately. Output can then be reduced to the required level. A ratio below one identifies a power deficit; unity marks the capacity boundary.

Available power includes the current, voltage, power and average-current-density ceilings. With zero contact resistance, it equals the minimum of $I_{\text{max}}^2 R$, V_{max}^2 / R , P_{max} and $(J_{\text{max}} \text{ A})^2 R$. Required power comes from the same enclosure heat-loss network used by the application. The map uses the temperature-dependent resistance and heat loss evaluated at 1200 °C.

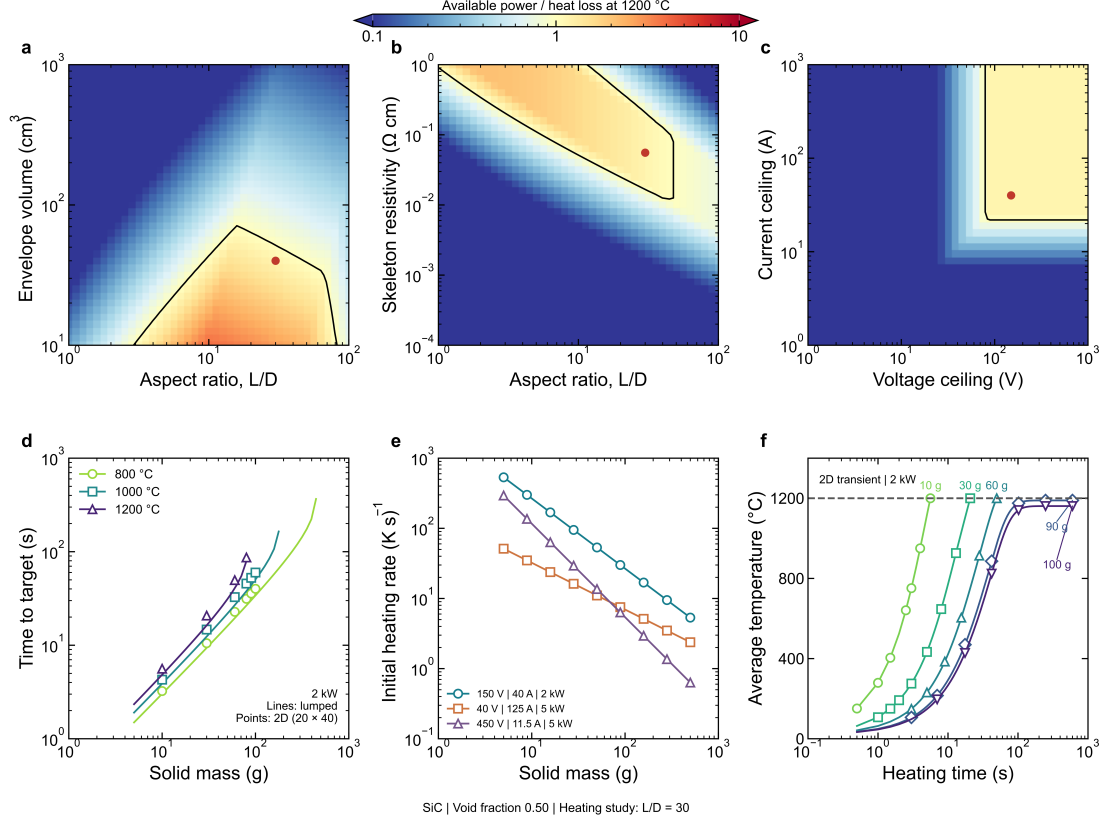


Figure 2. Heating capacity and startup of porous SiC elements. (a–c) Available element power divided by enclosure heat loss at 1200 °C, varying (a) envelope volume and aspect ratio, (b) skeleton resistivity and aspect ratio at 40 cm³, and (c) voltage and current ceilings at 40 cm³ and L/D = 30. The black contour marks unity. Red points identify the shared design at 150 V / 40 A / 2 kW. (d) Time to reach 800, 1000 and 1200 °C versus solid mass at L/D = 30 under the same supply limits. Lines integrate the lumped balance using the quasi-steady enclosure loss network; points are 2D transient calculations on a 20 × 40 grid with a 0.5 s step. Wall storage is included in 2D. (e) Initial heating rate under three commercial-rated supply envelopes. (f) 2D average-temperature histories. Curves that reach 1200 °C are displayed only up to that crossing; the other runs extend to 600 s. All cases use 50% porosity. The heating study uses constant SiC properties, effective conductivity 60 W/(m K), an external convection coefficient of 12 W/(m² K), ideal contacts and no reaction duty. Mass changes scale length and diameter together.

The capacity-map reference uses a smaller, 40 cm³ envelope at L/D = 30. Its available 2.00 kW exceeds the required 1.71 kW by 17.3% of the required power. Its target-temperature resistance is 3.56 Ω. This example differs from the 80 cm³ case used for the spatial grid study and transient calculation. Holding volume fixed in panel b separates the effect of resistivity and shape; holding the element fixed in panel c identifies the electrical specifications needed for the same target.

At low resistance the current ceiling limits heating; at high resistance the voltage ceiling limits it. When the power and current-density caps are inactive, the crossover is:

$$R(L^*) = \frac{V_{\max}}{I_{\max}}, \quad L^* = \sqrt{\frac{V_{\max}}{I_{\max}}} \frac{\mathcal{V}}{\rho_e} \quad (7)$$

This crossover marks the change in the active electrical constraint. Geometry also changes exposed area and enclosure losses, which affect the thermal optimum. In panel c, increasing both electrical ceilings eventually gives no further capacity because the power cap is fixed at 2 kW. The maps identify whether a design needs a change in resistance, supply capacity or heat loss to maintain the target under the stated porous-body approximation. Internal temperature distributions are examined separately in **Figure 3**. Figures S5 and S6 extend the screening to other materials and commercial supplies.

Startup introduces a mass-dependent time scale (**Figure 2d–f**). The lumped heating time is obtained by integrating $mC_p/(P - Q_{\text{loss}})$ over temperature using the application’s power and enclosure-loss functions. In panel d, the 0D lines use quasi-steady enclosure losses, whereas the 2D points include heat storage in the wall and surrounding domain; their heating times therefore differ. At fixed L/D and porosity, increasing solid mass enlarges both the element and its heat-loss area. The 2 kW supply heats the 10, 30 and 60 g cases to a mean 1200 °C in approximately 6, 21 and 50 s on the plotted grid. The 90 and 100 g cases remain below that target after 600 s. A larger rated supply can deliver less power to the same resistance: the 40 V / 125 A and 450 V / 11.5 A cases are voltage- and current-limited, respectively. These calculations use constant material properties and prescribed heat-transfer conditions.

3.3. Material-dependent temperature distributions

For the material comparison, each current is selected to give 900 °C in the 0D model for a 1.18 cm³ dense cylinder; the resulting 2D averages can differ. With these inputs, the calculated maximum–minimum spread is 7.9 K for SiC, 20.7 K for SiSiC, 33.9 K for Inconel 601 and 68.4 K for FeCrAl (**Figure 3**). The resolved SiC peak lies 2.8 K above its average; the FeCrAl peak lies 24.7 K above its average. The axial and radial profiles locate the differences that a single temperature omits. Spatial temperature variation also affects catalytic use of Joule-heated supports: Burentugs and Lobo reported nonuniform surface temperatures in a catalyst-coated FeCrAl coil.¹⁶ Malhotra et al. examined temperature homogeneity and solid–fluid equilibration in microwave-heated structured reactors.¹⁷

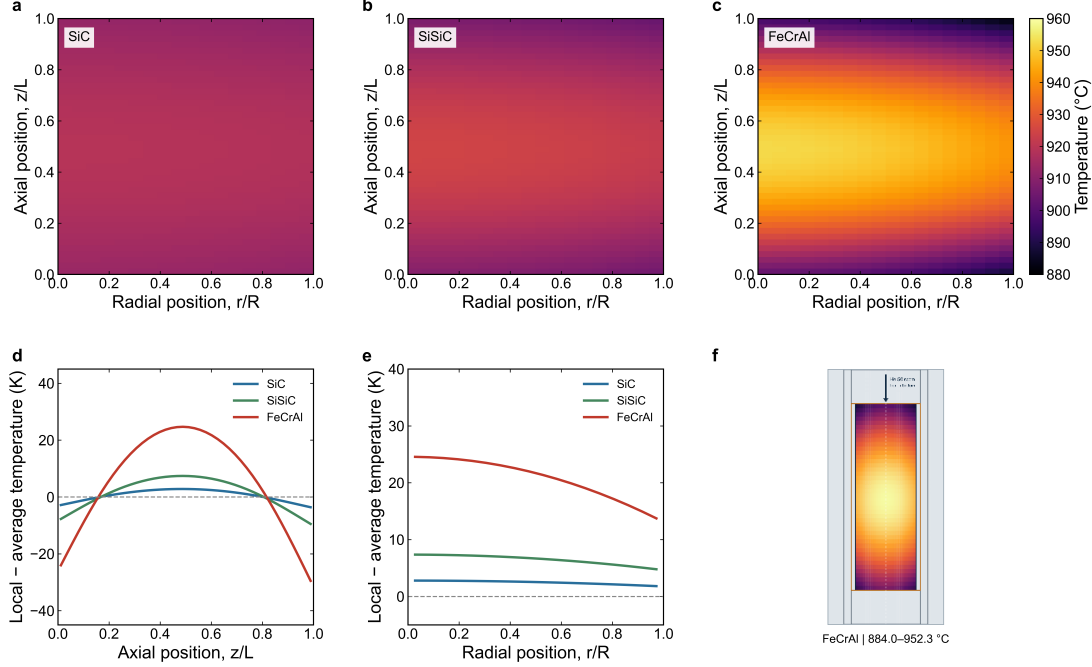


Figure 3. Material-dependent temperature distributions at a 900 °C lumped temperature. Dense cylinders have volume 1.18 cm³, $L/D = 3$, length 23.82 mm and diameter 7.94 mm. Each material uses its own current setpoint. (a–c) SiC, SiSiC and FeCrAl solid temperature fields on the same color scale. The radial and axial coordinates are independently normalized. (d) Centerline axial and (e) midplane radial temperatures relative to the respective volume averages. Lines connect calculated cell-center values. (f) ScreenJoule 2D thermal map calculated with the same FeCrAl inputs; the full reactor domain retains physical proportions and the application’s element-focused color mapping. The calculated mean and maximum are 927.6 and 952.3 °C. Panels a–e use the study fields archived with the calculation data. Resistivity and emissivity also differ among presets; conductivity is constant for SiC and FeCrAl and tabulated for SiSiC. Table S1 records input assumptions and operating points.

FeCrAl conductivity is held at 11 W m⁻¹ K⁻¹ across the temperature range. Inconel retains its tabulated temperature dependence. Resistivity, emissivity and delivered power also differ, so the contrasts cannot be assigned to conductivity alone. These compact dense elements form a separate case from the porous SiC design in **Figure 2**. Figure S3 examines the sensitivity of the porous design to thermal properties, enclosure losses and contact conditions.

3.4. Electrode contact width and supply limits

Electrode contact geometry affects both the spatial temperature distribution and the resistance seen by the supply. At 30 W, widening the electrode contact regions reduces the calculated temperature spread from 31.7 to 13.5 K (**Figure 4**). At higher setpoints, the wider contact regions reach the 375 A ceiling sooner, even though the requested power is well below the 15 kW rating. The delivered power at a 90 W setpoint falls from 70.1 to 55.0 W between the narrow and wide cases. Once current is limited, the lower resistance reduces I^2R heating. Electrode contact width therefore needs to be selected together with current capacity.

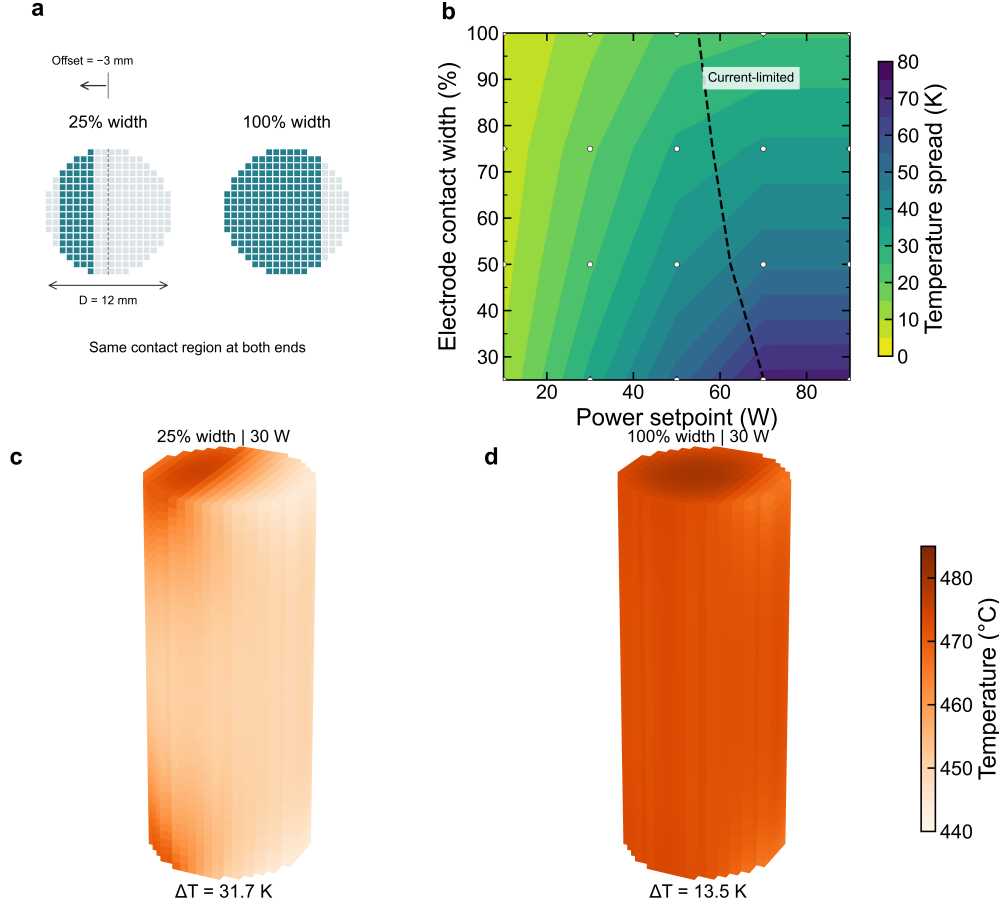


Figure 4. Electrode contact width and supply-constrained heating. (a) Electrode contact regions at 25% and 100% electrode contact width. Teal cells mark the electrode contacts. Width is the prescribed contact-band width divided by the 12 mm cylinder diameter; the band is clipped at the circular boundary. Both ends use the same band, centered at $x = -3$ mm (-50% of the 6 mm radius). (b) Steady temperature spread versus power setpoint and electrode contact width. White markers show 20 calculations; colors interpolate between them. The dashed line connects $I_{\max}^2 R$ at the four widths; points to its right are current-limited. (c,d) Temperature fields at 30 W for the two footprints, with a common color scale and view. Voxel faces are colored by adjacent-cell temperatures; surface temperatures are not reconstructed. The cylinder is 30 mm long and 12 mm in diameter, with constant resistivity $1.45 \times 10^{-6} \Omega \text{ m}$ and conductivity $11 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$. All cases use a 40 V / 375 A / 15 kW supply and an $18 \times 18 \times 45$ mesh. Electrodes are represented by ideal contact regions without finite electrode bodies or electrical contact resistance. Wider contact regions also change the exposed thermal area. The 3D views preserve physical proportions.

The two field calculations reproduce the browser-screening temperatures. Separate axisymmetric sensitivities quantify changes in peak temperature with contact resistance for the porous SiC case (Figure S3c).

3.5. Element geometry

At fixed power, geometry changes the exposed surface area and heat-loss paths, shifting the steady temperature and its distribution. For SiSiC elements of approximately 1 cm³ solid volume, the 150 V / 40 A / 2 kW supply delivers 100 W to all four geometries (**Figure 5**). The calculated mean temperature ranges from 844 °C for the hollow tube to 1033 °C for the solid cylinder. The narrow-center bar reaches the highest local temperature, 1052 °C, with a 76.6 K temperature spread; the reduced cross-section concentrates current and restricts axial heat conduction. The tube calculation exposes the bore to the same ambient heat-loss condition as the outer surface; enclosure radiation and internal gas conditions would change its thermal balance. Figure S8 gives the FeCrAl comparison with a 1000 A current ceiling.

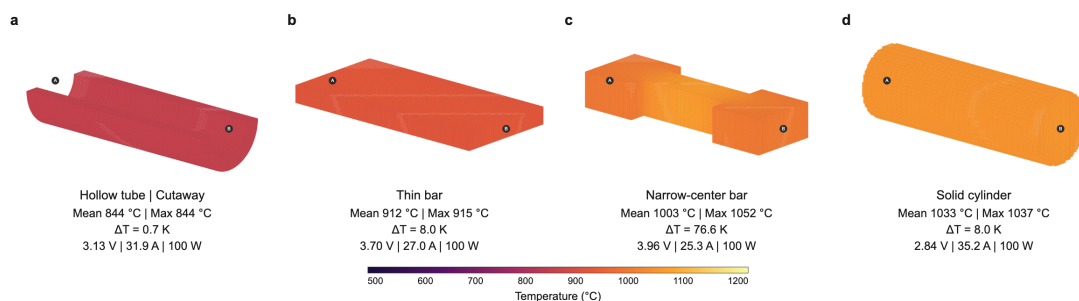


Figure 5. Steady temperature fields for four SiSiC geometries at 100 W: (a) hollow tube, (b) thin bar, (c) narrow-center bar, (d) solid cylinder. Panels are ordered by volume-average temperature and share the same viewing angle and 500–1200 °C color scale. The hollow tube uses a longitudinal half-cutaway; all reported temperatures refer to the complete body. ΔT is the maximum minus minimum solid temperature. Solid volumes are 1.000–1.021 cm³. The ScreenJoule SiSiC preset supplies tabulated resistivity and thermal conductivity, with density 3050 kg m⁻³ and heat capacity 680 J kg⁻¹ K⁻¹; the preset property tables and dimensions are recorded in the calculation settings. Every exposed surface, including the tube bore, exchanges heat with a 25 °C ambient through $h = 15 \text{ W m}^{-2} \text{ K}^{-1}$ and emissivity 0.8. Full-end ideal electrodes have zero contact resistance and zero electrode heat loss. Supply limits are 150 V, 40 A and 2 kW; all cases deliver 100 W within these limits and the prescribed $5 \times 10^6 \text{ A m}^{-2}$ current-density ceiling. The tube uses a $12 \times 96 \times 48$ annular mesh; the bars use $40 \times 16 \times 90$ and the cylinder $40 \times 40 \times 36$ Cartesian meshes. Images are captured from the browser-calculated fields.

3.6. Recommended use and scope

ScreenJoule calculates heating capacity and temperature distributions for material selection, element sizing, and diagnosis of insufficient heating. Users can first evaluate the available power and target-temperature feasibility with the lumped model, then examine temperature gradients and electrode configurations with the spatial models. Parameter sweeps quantify how element dimensions, supply ratings, and thermal boundaries affect heating. The models describe continuous conducting elements with prescribed properties; porous bodies are treated through effective properties. Particle-contact networks, pore-scale transport, reaction heat, and material degradation remain outside the present scope. Practical designs require measured material and contact properties, experimental confirmation, and assessment of temperature limits, electrical insulation, and protective controls.

4. Conclusions

ScreenJoule supports broad electrothermal screening followed by spatial analysis of selected reactor elements. Target-temperature maps identify combinations with sufficient heating capacity, and resolved fields quantify the internal gradients associated with selected designs. The electrode-contact-width study shows that wider contacts improve uniformity at fixed power while reducing available heating under a current ceiling. Users can compare element geometries, materials, power supplies, and electrode configurations before detailed reactor modeling or experiments. The open-source code allows users to extend material models, geometries, and boundary conditions, with each modification checked against the verification benchmarks.

Associated Content

Supporting Information contains geometry and property definitions, finite-volume equations, numerical diagnostics, boundary sensitivities, material-specific maps and supply comparisons. The public repository is available at <https://github.com/robin-yk/ScreenJoule>.

Acknowledgments

Generative AI tools assisted with website development, implementation of the three-dimensional flow and electrothermal models, and preparation of documentation and figures. The authors reviewed the code and verified the reported calculations.

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Supporting Information

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S1. Model and numerical methods

S1.1. Domain and boundaries

The reference SiC element has an envelope volume of 80 cm^3 and a void fraction of 0.50, surrounded by a 0.5 mm gap and a 1 mm quartz wall. Ambient and inlet temperatures are $20\text{ }^\circ\text{C}$, with external $h = 12\text{ W m}^{-2}\text{ K}^{-1}$. Steady and transient calculations use 30×60 and 20×40 meshes, respectively.

The axisymmetric domain comprises the r - z half-plane. The radial boundary is the symmetry axis $r = 0$. The outer radial face is fixed at the ambient temperature through the half-cell conductive resistance. At the two axial domain ends, nonflowing cells use the same fixed-ambient condition. Flow-connected gas cells use the prescribed inlet enthalpy at the top and advective outflow with zero axial conductive flux at the bottom. The element ends couple to the gas pads by conduction and radiation.

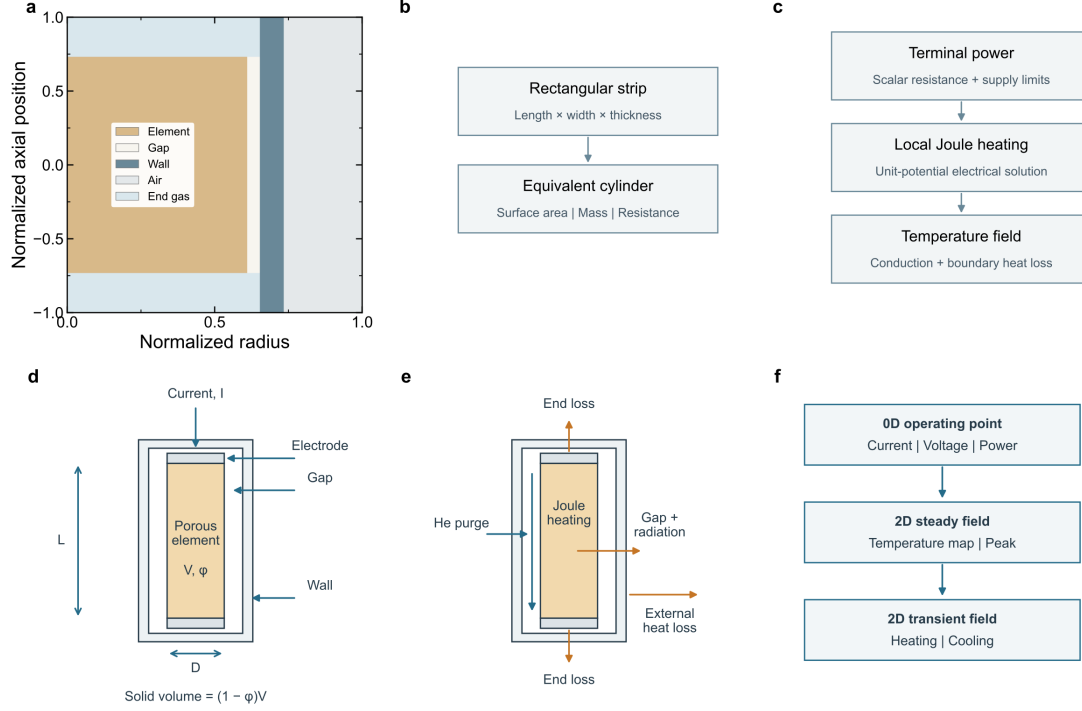


Figure S1. Computational domain and model approximations. (a) Material regions in normalized radial and axial coordinates; colors identify the element, gap, wall, surrounding air and end gas. The normalized plot does not preserve the physical aspect ratio. (b) Rectangular dimensions are used in the lumped calculation. The axisymmetric approximation uses an equivalent cylinder with matched radiating surface, mass and resistance. (c) Scalar terminal power normalizes the local Joule-heating distribution used in the thermal calculation. The field-derived resistance does not replace the scalar terminal resistance. (d) Axial element, gap and wall schematic with idealized electrode contacts. (e) Heat-transfer paths through the enclosure and ends. (f) Lumped and axisymmetric calculation sequence. Panels d–f describe the 0D/2D formulation; individual pores and resolved electrode geometry are omitted in this schematic.

S1.2. Geometry and properties

$$V_{env} = \frac{V_s}{f_s}, \quad D = \left(\frac{4V_{env}}{\pi\lambda} \right)^{1/3}, \quad L = \lambda D, \quad A_{eff} = f_s \frac{\pi D^2}{4}, \quad A_s = \pi D L + \frac{\pi D^2}{2} \quad (S1)$$

In the porous-body approximation, the solid fraction determines the conducting area and thermal storage. An independently specified isotropic effective thermal conductivity describes heat conduction; individual pore channels are not resolved. Properties specified per bulk volume are used without a second porosity correction. For a rectangular element of length L , width W , and thickness H , $V_{env} = LWH$, $A_{eff} = f_s WH$, and $S = 2(LW + LH + WH)$. The zero-dimensional calculation uses the rectangular dimensions; the axisymmetric solver substitutes a cylinder with the same length and radiating surface, with effective density preserving mass and effective resistivity preserving resistance (Figure S1b).

Temperature-dependent properties are specified as tabulated values, tabulated resistivity multipliers, or a linear temperature coefficient; constant properties are also supported. Outside a tabulated range, the nearest endpoint value is retained. The linear resistivity expression is limited to a

minimum of 5% of its room-temperature value,

$$\rho_e(T) = \rho_0 \max[0.05, 1 + \alpha_p(T_C - 20)] \quad (\text{S2})$$

The zero-dimensional model solves $P_{bulk}(T) = Q_{loss}(T)$ by bracketing and bisection. In the direct-surface limit $Q_{loss} = \varepsilon\sigma_{SB}A_s(T^4 - T_a^4) + hA_s(T - T_g)$; the enclosure model replaces this with element-to-wall conduction and radiation, wall conduction, outside-air conduction, external convection, boundary radiation, and axial losses. The zero-dimensional result initializes the 2D iteration and supplies the lumped comparisons in Figure 2 and the associated Supporting Information.

S1.3. Finite-volume discretization

For a finite volume bounded by radial coordinates r_w, r_e and axial edges z_s, z_n ,

$$V_p = \pi(r_e^2 - r_w^2)(z_n - z_s), \quad A_w = 2\pi r_w \Delta z, \quad A_e = 2\pi r_e \Delta z, \quad A_s = A_n = \pi(r_e^2 - r_w^2) \quad (\text{S3})$$

The thermal conductance between adjacent cells p and q is obtained from the sum of the two half-cell thermal resistances,

$$G_{pq} = \frac{A_f}{d_p/k_p + d_q/k_q} \quad (\text{S4})$$

The resulting intercell fluxes enter the neighboring energy balances with opposite signs. The linearized radiative heat-transfer coefficient is $h_{rad} = \varepsilon\sigma_{SB}(T + T_s)(T^2 + T_s^2)$; for concentric element and wall surfaces,

$$\varepsilon_{eff} = \left[\frac{1}{\varepsilon_e} + \frac{R_e}{R_w} \left(\frac{1}{\varepsilon_w} - 1 \right) \right]^{-1} \quad (\text{S5})$$

Element-to-wall radiation is evaluated between nonadjacent cells in parallel with conduction through the gap. External convection acts at wall-air interfaces, wall radiation exchanges heat with the prescribed ambient, and the surrounding-air cells conduct heat to the outer boundary. At a helium flow rate of 50 sccm, the heat-capacity rate is $\dot{C}_{He} = 7.73 \times 10^{-4} \text{ W K}^{-1}$; each downstream gas row receives enthalpy from the corresponding upstream cell. Velocity, pressure, density variation, recirculation, and natural convection are not calculated.

S1.4. Field solution

The electrical potential is calculated within the element using terminal potentials of 0 and 1 V and zero normal current at the curved surface. Face electrical conductances follow eq S4 with thermal conductivity replaced by electrical conductivity. The face dissipation contributions are summed for each cell and normalized to P_{bulk} . The field-derived resistance is reported and does not replace the scalar R_{total} .

The lumped steady temperature initializes the field on a fixed mesh. Each Picard iteration evaluates T_{avg} and updates scalar resistivity, resistance, current and P_{bulk} . The solver then solves the unit-potential problem and updates thermal conductivity, heat capacity, gas enthalpy and radiation coefficients. It assembles and solves the thermal matrix, then under-relaxes the field using $T^{n+1} = T^n + \omega(T^* - T^n)$, with ω initially set to 0.62. Convergence is assessed from the temperature step, linear residual and energy closure (Figure S1c). Jacobi preconditioning scales each row by

its diagonal. Preconditioned conjugate gradients (PCG) solve the symmetric operator; BiCGSTAB handles the nonsymmetric operator produced by directed gas transport, both to a relative tolerance of 10^{-11} . Backward Euler adds $\rho c_p V / \Delta t$ to the diagonal with the heat capacity evaluated at the midpoint of the step. The closure metric is

$$\varepsilon_E = \frac{|P_{bulk} - Q_{boundary} - \dot{E}_{stored}|}{\max(P_{bulk}, Q_{boundary}, |\dot{E}_{stored}|, 10^{-12})} \quad (S6)$$

Stored energy is obtained by integrating heat capacity over temperature and accounting for the porous solid fraction. The transient discretization evaluates heat capacity at the midpoint of each time step. When a step crosses a property-table knot, the discrete energy balance and the integrated stored-energy change can differ because they use different heat-capacity evaluations.

S2. Numerical verification

The manufactured-solution test gives approximately second-order convergence, with a finest-mesh L2 error of 0.0223 K. The two finest physical meshes differ in peak temperature by 0.079 K. The largest annular discrepancy at $L/D = 100$ is 1.95%; reducing the time step from 2.5 to 1.25 s changes the endpoint temperature by 1.327 K. All 112 regression tests pass.

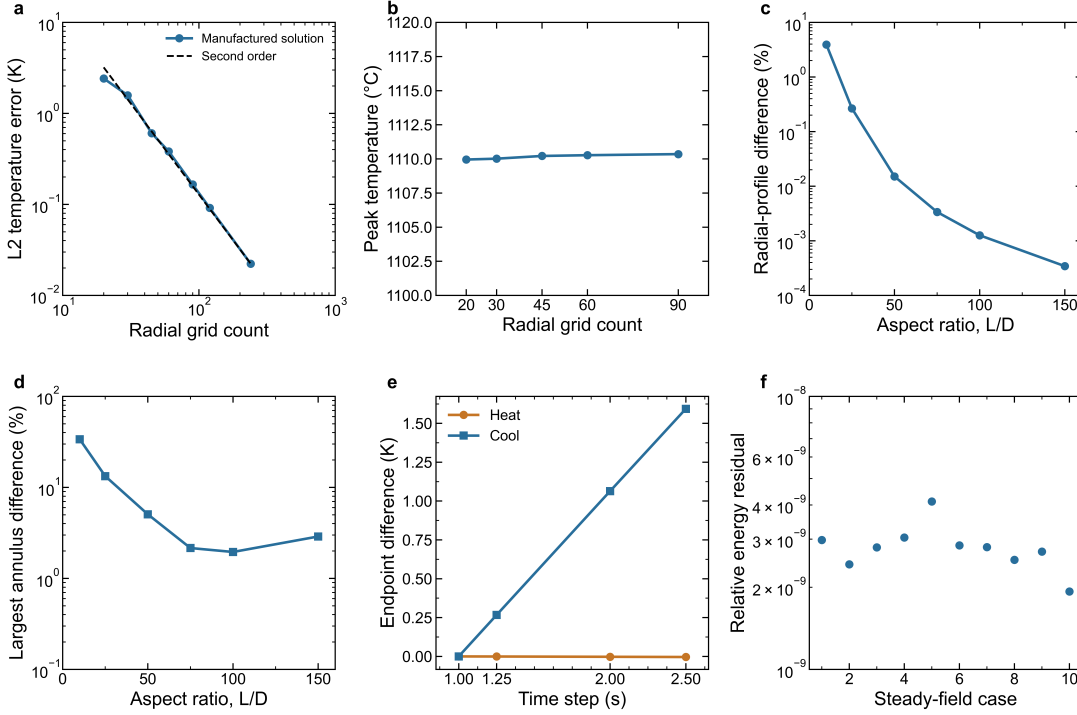


Figure S2. Numerical verification. (a) Manufactured-solution errors on seven grids with 20, 30, 45, 60, 90, 120 and 240 radial cells and twice as many axial cells. The dashed line gives second-order scaling anchored to the finest grid. (b) Porous SiC peak temperature on five meshes with 20, 30, 45, 60 and 90 radial cells. The two finest meshes differ by 0.079 K. (c,d) Finite-cylinder calculations at $L/D = 10, 25, 50, 75, 100$ and 150 compared with radial-parabola and annular-conduction solutions for infinitely long cylinders. Deviations include finite-end effects. (e) End-of-leg mean-temperature differences for time steps of 1, 1.25, 2 and 2.5 s, relative to the 1 s result for each leg. Each

heating leg starts at ambient and lasts 300 s; its 300 s cooling leg starts from the corresponding heated field. (f) Relative energy residuals for the original ten steady-field cases. Symbols show calculations; connecting lines guide the eye. Energy-balance closure and temporal convergence are separate checks.

S3. Design sensitivities

S3.1. Material comparison

Table S1. Inputs and calculated operating points for Figure 3. Values use the 30×60 mesh. Ceramic cases use 150 V / 40 A / 2 kW ceilings; alloy cases use 40 V / 375 A / 15 kW ceilings, with current setpoints below those limits. Contacts are ideal and lead losses are omitted; low terminal voltage makes the alloy cases sensitive to those omissions.

Material	k at 2D average (W m ⁻¹ K ⁻¹)	Current (A)	Voltage (V)	Bulk power (W)	2D average / peak (°C)	Preset source / thermal model
SiC	120.0	13.85	3.701	51.27	916.1 / 918.9	Mittal et al. (2025), Table 1; Constant k proxy
SiSiC	48.1	26.64	2.028	54.03	917.1 / 924.5	550-750 °C bulk back-calculated from Zheng et al., AIChE J. 69, e17620 (2023), Table 2; RT branch is a commercial SiC-element proxy; Tabulated k(T)
FeCrAl	11.0	258.15	0.187	48.17	927.6 / 952.3	Kanthal resistance materials handbook; Constant k proxy
Inconel 601	26.5	290.97	0.176	51.30	921.2 / 933.2	Special Metals Inconel 601 bulletin, Table 3; Tabulated k(T)

Refinement from 30×60 to 45×90 cells changes the SiC and FeCrAl temperature extrema by at most 1.43 K. All four material cases converge with relative energy residuals below 6×10^{-10} . MoSi₂ is excluded because the selected geometry cannot reach the matched target within its preset current-density limit.

S3.2. Thermal properties and contacts

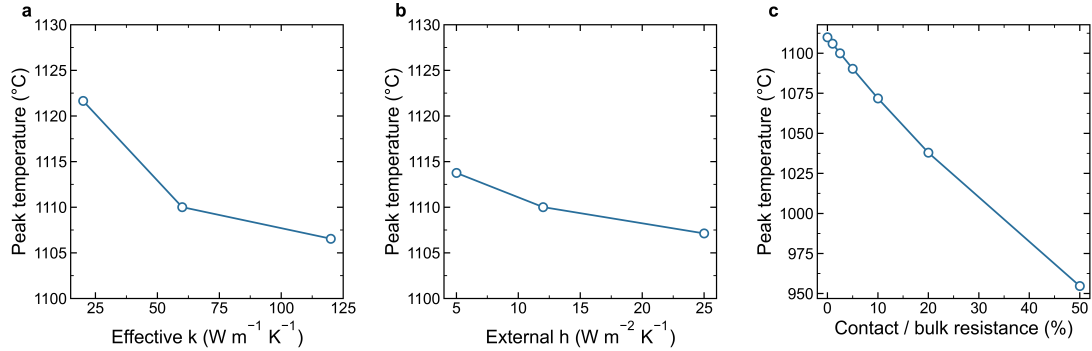


Figure S3. Sensitivity of the steady-state peak element temperature for the selected porous SiC geometry. (a) Effective thermal conductivity. (b) External convection coefficient. (c) Combined resistance of both electrical contacts divided by the bulk element resistance evaluated at 1200 °C.

Contact resistance is prescribed for the sensitivity sweep and held constant with temperature; bulk resistance varies with temperature. Contact power is tracked separately from bulk Joule heating. Contact temperature and heat returned from the electrodes are not resolved.

For Figure S3c, the combined contact resistance spans 0–50% of the bulk resistance at 1200 °C (2.8238 Ω), corresponding to 0–1.4119 Ω . Interface resistivity equals half the combined contact resistance multiplied by the model current-carrying area.

S3.3. Element dimensions

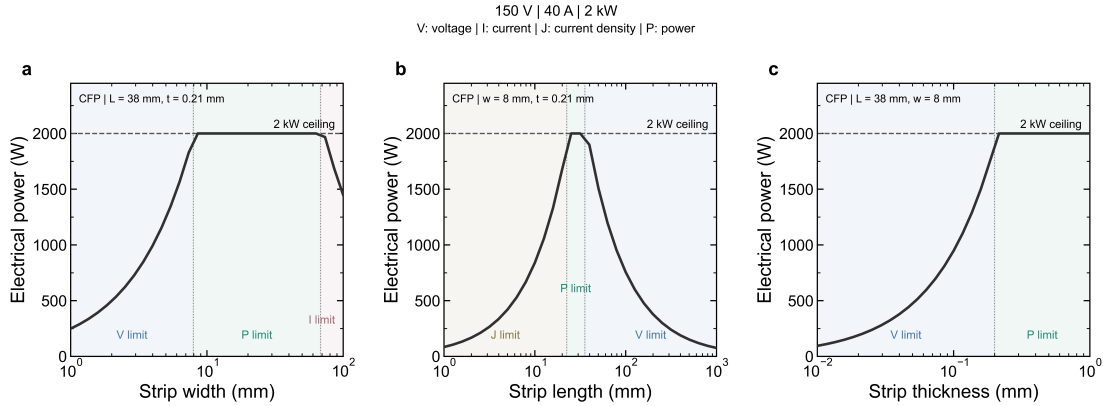


Figure S4. Electrical constraints during dimensional sweeps under 150 V, 40 A and 2 kW supply ceilings and the preset current-density limit. Shaded regions identify the active constraint at each calculated operating point; dotted boundaries are placed between adjacent samples and are not exact transition locations. (a) CFP width at fixed length and thickness. Increasing width lowers resistance, shifting operation from voltage limitation through the power ceiling to current limitation. (b) CFP length at fixed cross-section. Power increases under the current-density limit, reaches the power ceiling and decreases under the voltage limit. (c) CFP thickness at fixed length and width. Increasing thickness reduces resistance until the power ceiling is reached. All panels report electrical power. Dimensional changes also affect mass and exposed area, so temperature requires a thermal calculation. The electrical comparisons include cases above 1200 °C.

S3.4. Materials and supplies

The material calculations use the specified preset properties and material-dependent geometry ranges. Power-supply envelopes are constructed from the nominal ratings supplied by the author; transient response and derating are not specified.

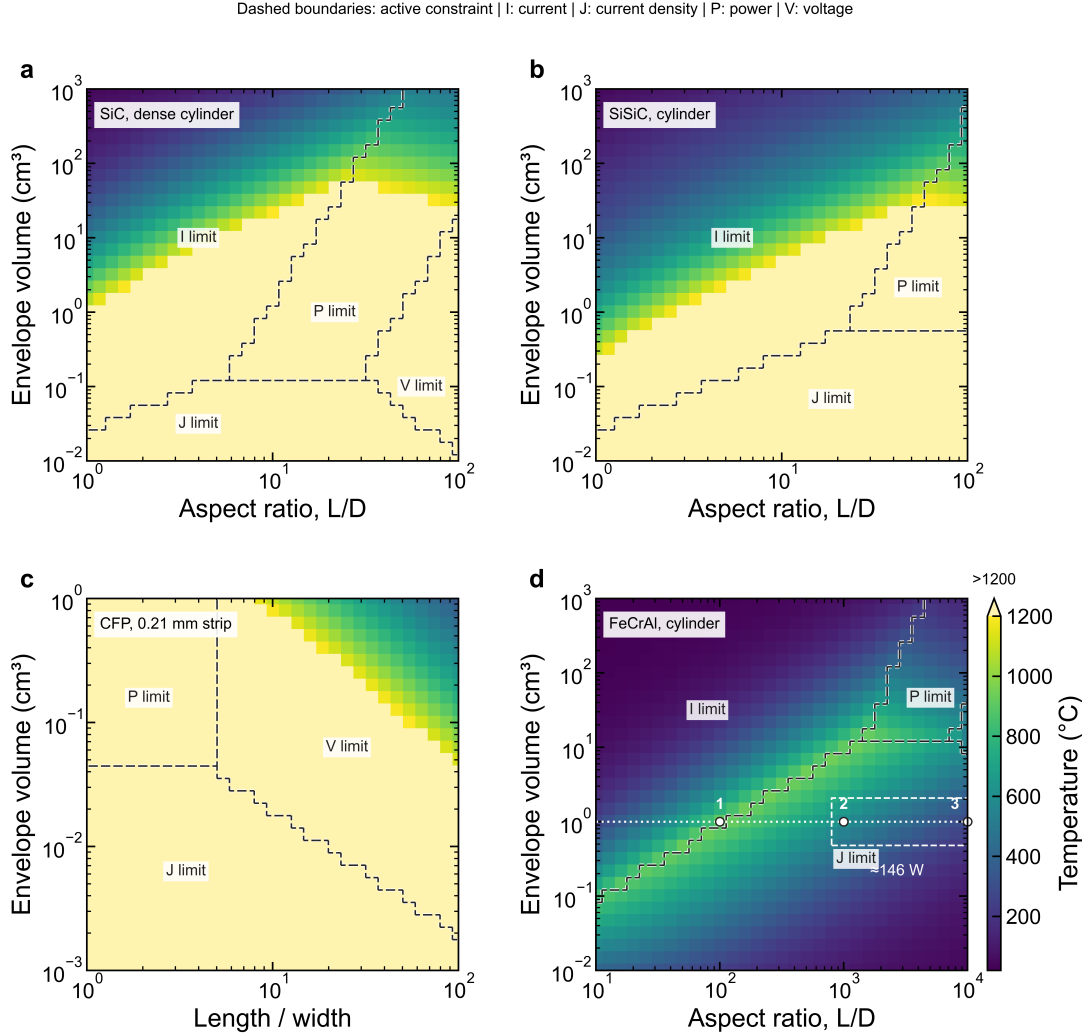


Figure S5. Lumped material screening under 150 V, 40 A and 2 kW limits: (a) dense SiC cylinder, (b) SiSiC cylinder, (c) CFP strip of 0.21 mm thickness and (d) FeCrAl cylinder.

Pale yellow indicates temperatures above 1200 °C. Dashed boundaries identify current (I), current-density (J), power (P), and voltage (V) limits. The CFP panel uses length-to-width ratio and a separate volume range. Each panel uses its own material properties and geometry range.

In panel d, the 1 cm³ cylinders become cooler as L/D increases from 1000 to 10000: the current-density limit holds power near 146 W while exposed area increases. These calculations treat straight cylinders.

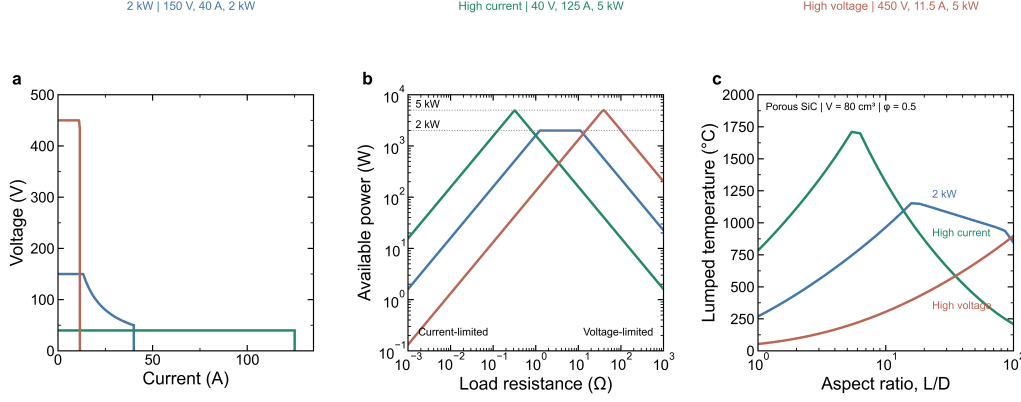


Figure S6. Power-supply selection from electrical ratings to predicted temperature. (a) Positive-quadrant upper operating boundaries for the 62020H-150S (blue), 62050H-40 (green) and 62050H-450 (red), using nominal voltage, current and power ceilings. (b) Available power versus load resistance, $\min(I_{\text{max}}^2 R, V_{\text{max}}^2/R, P_{\text{max}})$, before material current-density limits. Low resistance is current-limited and high resistance is voltage-limited. (c) Lumped temperatures for porous SiC at an 80 cm^3 envelope volume and 0.5 solid fraction as L/D varies; preset current-density limits are included. Colors identify the same supplies in all panels. The compared supplies have different rated powers. Dynamic response, ripple and derating are not modeled.

S3.5. FeCrAl geometries

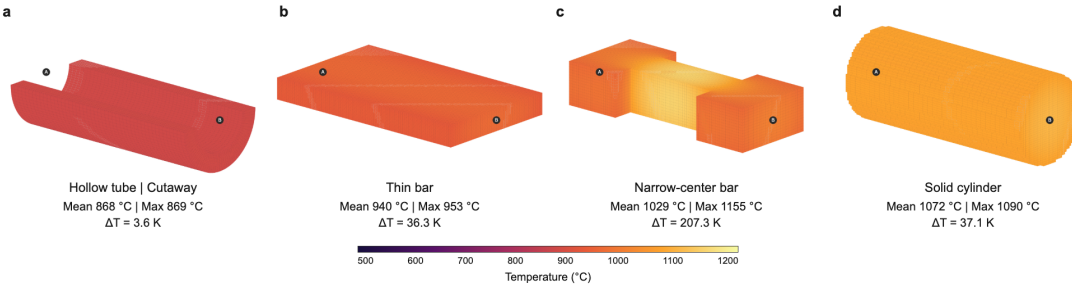


Figure S8. Steady temperature fields for four FeCrAl geometries at 100 W: (a) hollow tube, (b) thin rectangular bar, (c) bar with a narrow center, and (d) solid cylinder. Panels are ordered by volume-average temperature and share the same viewing angle and 500–1200 $^{\circ}\text{C}$ color scale. Panel a uses a longitudinal half-cutaway; all reported temperatures refer to the complete body. ΔT is the maximum minus minimum solid temperature.

The FeCrAl elements have solid volumes of $1.000\text{--}1.021 \text{ cm}^3$, resistivity $1.45 \times 10^{-6} \Omega \text{ m}$, and thermal conductivity $11 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$. All exposed surfaces, including the bore, exchange heat with a $25 \text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$ ambient through $h = 15 \text{ W m}^{-2} \text{ K}^{-1}$ and emissivity 0.8. Ideal full-end electrodes contribute no contact resistance or heat loss. The $150 \text{ V} / 1000 \text{ A} / 2 \text{ kW}$ limits permit 100 W in every geometry.

S4. Literature comparisons

Figure S7 separates three comparisons: the Wismann case estimates the equivalent insulation needed for $800 \text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$; the Zheng case calibrates heat loss at one point and compares temperatures at nine other points using reported power and enthalpy duty; the CEJ case evaluates exposed-surface

temperature sensitivity to convection at the reported voltage range.

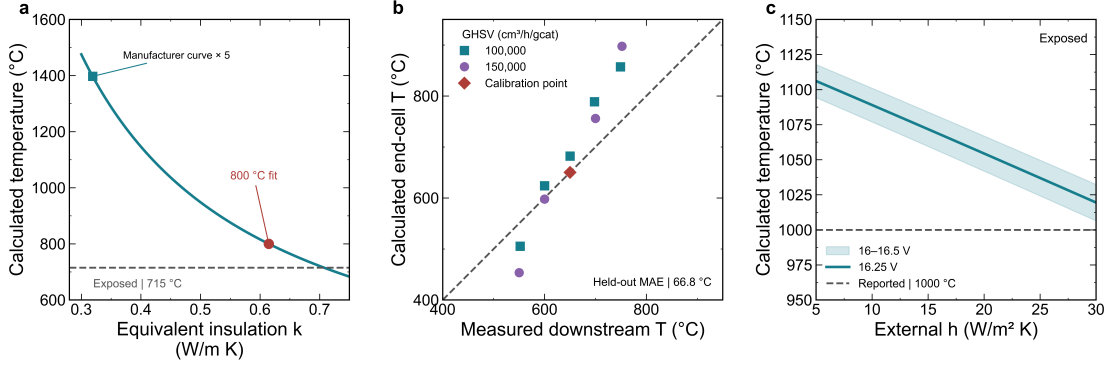


Figure S7. Thermal-boundary sensitivity and literature comparisons. (a) Calculated tube temperature versus equivalent insulation conductivity for a Wismann-geometry case at 435.3 W. The dashed line denotes exposed outer-surface heat loss; the red point denotes conductivity fitted to 800 °C. The square uses an approximate manufacturer conductivity curve multiplied by five, evaluated at the mean insulation temperature. (b) Zheng downstream temperatures and calculated end-adjacent solid-cell means for ten reported operating points. (c) Exposed-surface 0D CFP temperature versus assumed external convection coefficient. The solid line uses 16.25 V; shading spans 16–16.5 V. The dashed line denotes the nominal 1000 °C CEJ condition.

FeCrAl tube (Wismann). Equivalent insulation conductivity is fitted to 800 °C using the prescribed power. That power is not independently matched to the reported operating point, and reaction and gas enthalpy loads are omitted. The fit therefore estimates equivalent system heat loss.

SiSiC foam (Zheng). Reported power and enthalpy duty are inputs. A surface heat-loss coefficient of $17.05 \text{ W m}^{-2} \text{ K}^{-1}$ is fitted at 650 °C and $\text{GHSV} = 150,000 \text{ cm}^3 \text{ h}^{-1} \text{ gcat}^{-1}$, then retained for the other nine points (mean absolute error 66.8 °C). End-cell temperature represents the downstream measurement; the contactor and thermocouple are not resolved.

Carbon fiber paper (Mittal and Kwak). The exposed CFP strip is represented by an equivalent cylinder at ambient 20 °C and emissivity 0.57. Gas enthalpy and clamp conduction are omitted. The voltage interval represents the reported operating range.

Nomenclature

Symbol	Meaning	Units
r, z	radial and axial coordinates; $r = 0$ is the symmetry axis	m
$T(r, z), T_{avg}$	temperature field; volume average over the element	K
$\rho_e(T), \sigma(T)$	electrical resistivity and conductivity	$\Omega \text{ m}, \text{S m}^{-1}$
Φ	electric potential in the unit-potential problem	V
L, D, λ	element length, equivalent diameter, aspect ratio L/D	m, m, –
$V_s, \mathcal{V}, A_{eff}$	conducting solid volume $A_{eff}L$; effective conducting area	m^3, m^2
R_{bulk}, R_c, R_{total}	element resistance; one contact; $R_{bulk} + 2R_c$	Ω
I, J_{max}	operating current; ceiling on I/A_{eff}	A, A m^{-2}

Symbol	Meaning	Units
$P_{bulk}, P_{contact}$	$I^2 R_{bulk}$ deposited; $I^2(2R_c)$ reported	W
q''', q'''_{unit}	deposited source; unnormalized dissipation at 1 V	W m ⁻³
$k(T), c_p(T)$	thermal conductivity; specific heat	W m ⁻¹ K ⁻¹ , J kg ⁻¹ K ⁻¹
h, h_{rad}, h_{eff}	convection, linearized radiation, and combined surface coefficient	W m ⁻² K ⁻¹
τ	lumped time constant $mc_p/(h_{eff}S)$	s